

together, and within a few years, a cult had grown up around his memory.

Treated like criminals

By the middle of the 1st century CE, the new religion (Christianity) had reached Rome. Christians were seen as a threat, because their belief in one supreme god challenged the Roman belief in many gods. Rome persecuted Christians who would not worship other gods. Christians were forced to hold their meetings in secret. Rumors

WEIRD WORLD

DID CHRISTIANS DIE IN THE COLOSSEUM? MAYBE, MAYBE NOT. CONTRARY TO POPULAR BELIEF, THERE IS NO EVIDENCE THAT CHRISTIANS WERE EVER KILLED THERE.

spread that they were involved in criminal activities. When a large part of Rome was destroyed by fire in 64 CE, Emperor Nero blamed the Christians for starting it. From then on, a new spectacle was seen in the city. Nero rounded up Christians and had them executed—some were tied to posts, covered in pitch, and set on fire. These human torches burned through the night on the grounds of Nero's palace. He treated others like common criminals and had them either beheaded or thrown to the beasts in the city's arena (a wooden one that existed until the Colosseum was built some years later).

However, this persecution had little effect in curbing the spread of the Christian religion. In time, it proved stronger even than the might of Rome itself.



IN THIS IMAGINATIVE PAINTING MADE IN THE 1800S, CHRISTIANS ARE KILLED BY WILD ANIMALS IN A ROMAN ARENA.